The most complicated time that requires explicit control over Elixir, Erlang, and the BEAM is during installation. Unfortunately, this is also the first experience you'll have! So let's specifically cover best practices for installation.

Install Elixir on Your Computer

When you install Elixir on your computer, you *must* properly install the right Erlang/OTP versions or you could run into frustrating errors. You should always specify versions of each so that everything works as you expect it to. This is because Elixir frequently calls OTP functions, which rely on having the correct version installed.

If you don't know where to get started, just pick the latest version for each. Things might slightly change over time, but you can always adapt or combine different versions as needed.

I recommend the asdf[13] version manager with plugins for asdf-elixir[14] and asdf-erlang.[15] These plugins do a good job at managing the installation needs of compiling Erlang/OTP over time, so you're most likely to succeed with them. You can find online guides[16] that walk you through how to set up asdf.

You can use asdf in a few ways, but you'll have the most success if you create a `.tool-versions` file in your project root and commit it to version control. Here's an example of that file with the tool versions used during the production of this book:

.tool-versions

```
elixir 1.16.0-otp-26
erlang 26.2.1
```

Once you have asdf installed—along with the Elixir and Erlang plugins—you can run `asdf install` in the directory with this file, and it will install the correct versions.

Notice that the Elixir version uses the `-otp` suffix. This tells asdf to install the Elixir version that has been compiled with a specific Erlang/OTP version.

The `.tool-versions` file allows your entire team to have the same version of Elixir and Erlang/OTP. This also makes it clear which versions are required when you deploy code to production.

13. https://github.com/asdf-vm/asdf
14. https://github.com/asdf-vm/asdf-elixir
15. https://github.com/asdf-vm/asdf-erlang
16. https://thinkingelixir.com/install-elixir-using-asdf/